7.10 Þjórsárdalur, Iceland: Significance of cultural landscape

Uggi Ævarsson

Location and background

Þjórsárdalur (valley of the river Þjórsá) lays at the skirt of the southern interior highlands of Iceland. One of Iceland's longest rivers, Þjórsá, meanders by the valley's mouth. The volcano Hekla looms over the valley to the south. The valley is heavily eroded and vegetation sparse, and is regularly blasted by pumice from Mt. Hekla along with other volcanos. The valley is fork shaped with the mountain Reykholt and a batch of pseudo-craters in the middle splitting it in two (Figs.52 & 55). River Fossá (waterfall-river) runs along the western side of the valley and enters it from the northeast plateau with quite an entrance: 122 m high waterfall, Háifoss. The devastating forces of nature, erosion, accumulative elements of ash – fall and the constructive vegetation have been duelling through the centuries.

Roughly in the mid-19th century Þjórsárdalur was systematically surveyed by an antiquarian, Brynjúlfur Jónsson from neighbouring farm Minni-Núpur (Ragnheiður Gló Gylfadóttir, 2021). It was the first time in Iceland that archaeological survey was carried out systematically. By this time the valley had been eroding for decades and cultural ruins were slowly being exposed by wind and lack of vegetation, with remains of around twenty sites slowly coming to light. In Brynjúlfur's eyes the valley was like a stage design for the settlement era – the Viking age.

In 1939 a team of pan-Nordic archaeologists excavated six sites in Þjórsárdalur, Skallakot (Aage Roussell), Stöng (Aage Roussell), Snjáleifartóftir (Mårten Stenberger), Áslákstunga fremri (Mårten Stenberger), Skeljastaðir (Matthías Þórðarson) and Stórhólshlíð (Jouko Voionmaa). It was a breakthrough, and this expedition marked the beginning of archaeology as a scientific profession in Iceland. Furthermore, it yielded the development of tephrochronology as a dating method: where each volcanic ash layer is sourced and dated from its composition and bearings to other ash layers. As well as this important scientific breakthrough, the work in the valley was conducted by a number of young archaeologists who went on to become significant figures in the profession, and indeed the nation (one became president of Iceland).

The significance of archaeology as scientific research is quite apparent in the case of Þjórsárdalur: not only did the findings and conclusions of the excavations make a huge impact on understanding the past in general but also established archaeology, tephrochronology and osteology as professions in Iceland. Þjórsárdalur is considered – by Icelandic archaeologists at least – to be the cradle of archaeology in Iceland, because of the actual remains themselves and the development of archaeological method.

It is our role as heritage managers to develop and broaden ideas, and Þjórsárdalur is a good example of the development of the concept of cultural landscape protection, rather than just sites and monuments.

Figure 52: Site of Reykholt, looking north. (Uggi Ævarsson).

Figure 53: Remains of a byre, site of Stöng. (Uggi Ævarsson).

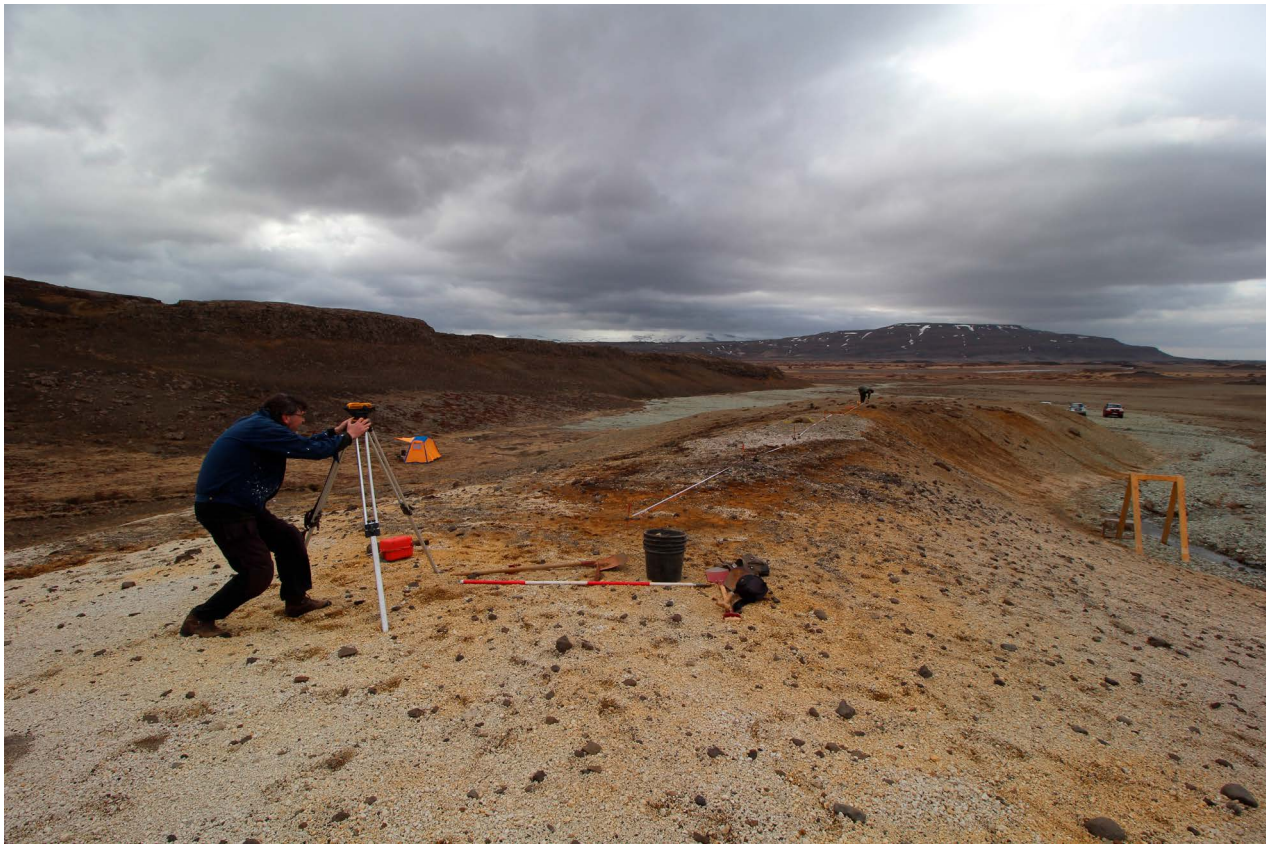

Figure 54: Excavation at Bergsstaðir, looking south. (Uggi Ævarsson).

Reasons for assessments and assessing significance

Þjórsárdalur was mostly abandoned in the beginning of the 12th century due to a devastating ash-fall from Mt Hekla in 1104. In 1300AD Hekla expectorated heavily and sealed the valley's fate. The interior of the valley was never to be inhabited again. Which means that the cultural landscape is 'frozen' in the early 12th century; it is untouched by later agricultural use or other landscape development.

Since 1927 the ruins in Þjórsárdalur have been protected. Only a small number of archaeological investigations have been carried out since 1939, although in recent years more has taken place: in Sandártunga, Bergsstaðir, Reykholt, Stöng (Figs. 52 & 54). Even though there have been different opinions within the heritage management of how and if protected sites should be excavated still there is a consensus of the importance of these sites in Þjórsárdalur. In later times the idea that the space between the sites is of equal importance to the sites themselves – the cultural landscape as a whole – has developed. The term "búsetulandslag" (settlement landscape) is used along with the term cultural landscape in a bit narrower sense: it covers the farms and the belonging structures, the routes between farms, fields, meadows and pastures, hunting and fishing grounds, placenames, stories and memories; the land people lived in, were formed by and formed themselves (Orri Vésteinsson, 2020).

The main 'threat' to the cultural landscape in the valley today is not the wind but the tourists which have grown in numbers and are expected to continue to do so in the near future. As elsewhere in Iceland there is a strong will to plant trees everywhere but it is vital from the perspective of the cultural landscape to control the planting in a dialogue with the forestry department and the Environmental Agency. In 1969 the first mega hydro-electric power plant in Iceland was completed at the valley's mouth. It is still going strong and has been extended in recent years.

The municipality and other stakeholders in the area respect the archaeology and its significance, even though it takes some arguing at times. For the first time in Icelandic history a vast area of land – a whole valley of 140 km² – was declared protected in 2021 (Fig.55). A few farms were excluded since they were hesitant to become a part of a protected area, which complicated

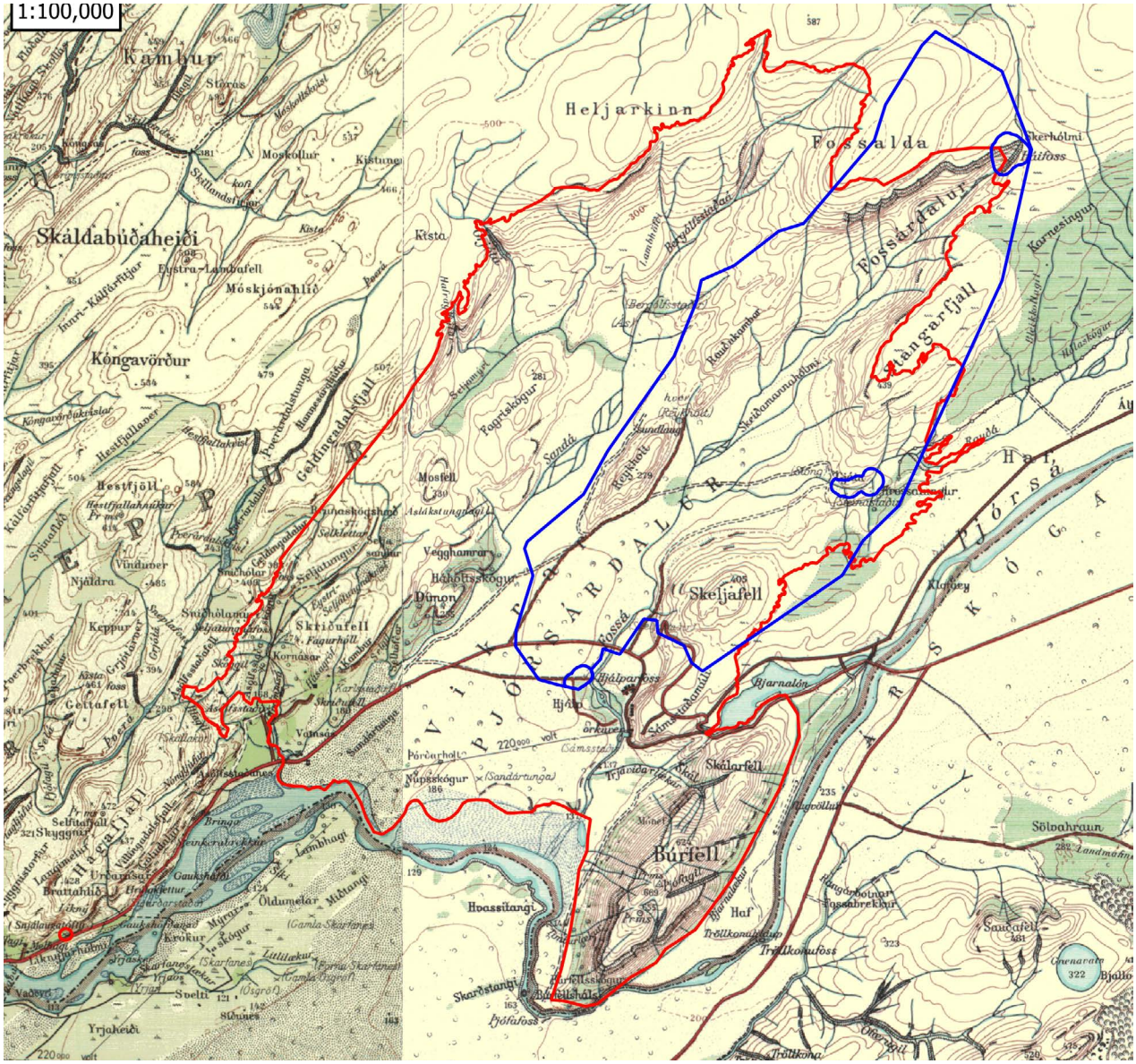

Figure 55: Map showing areas of the valley under Cultural Landscape Protection (red) and Environmental Protection (blue). (Oddgeir Isaksen)

the boundaries of the area a little but not dramatically. The Environmental Agency of Iceland protected certain areas in the valley as well. Since cultural and environmental landscapes go hand in hand these two institutions are leading the development work in the valley: building shelters over ruins, making parking areas, trails, bridges, toilets and interpretative material, with backup from the municipality which the more basic infrastructure leans on.

The aim of the Cultural Heritage Agency is to make Þjórsárdalur attractive to guests because of the archaeology without compromise – resting on the truth value instead of creating a 'theme park'. The only way to do so is to research and cherish the sites (and the area between them!) and make them inviting to guests through well designed infrastructure. How to mediate archaeological sites is of great importance. The Heritage Agency is focusing on ways to communicate the past in such a way it does not take over the ambience of the deserted valley: concentrating on low-key, low-tech solutions that make the guests become a part of an experience and inspiration rather than being passive consumers.